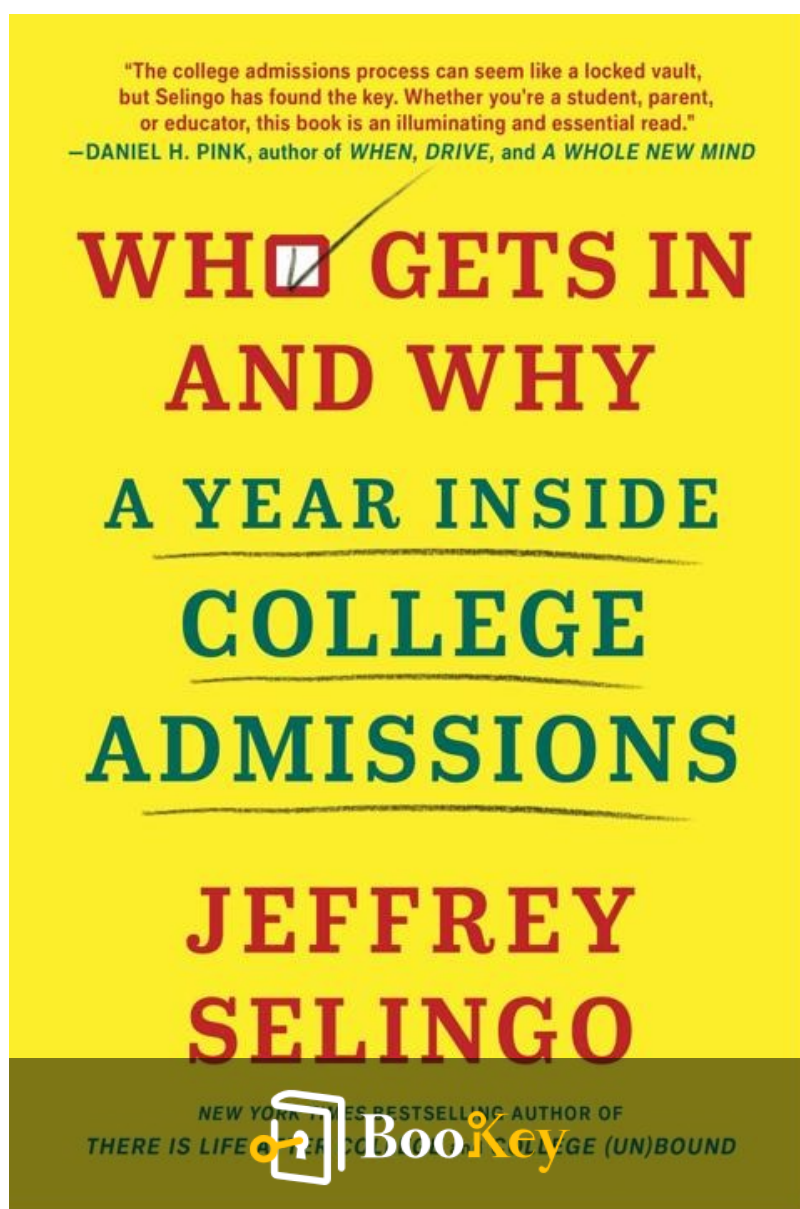


Who Gets In and Why PDF

Jeffrey J. Selingo



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Unlocking the Secrets of College Admissions
Decisions.

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About the book

In "Who Gets In and Why," award-winning journalist and New York Times bestselling author Jeffrey J. Selingo offers an eye-opening exploration of the college admissions process from within the walls of three distinct institutions. With acceptance rates at top universities plummeting, Selingo challenges traditional beliefs about what it takes to succeed in the competitive admissions landscape. Drawing from his firsthand experiences embedded in selective private universities, liberal arts colleges, and flagship public campuses, he reveals how factors like institutional agendas, diversity, and financial considerations heavily influence admissions decisions. By following students and their families through this complex journey, Selingo encourages prospective college applicants—and their parents—to rethink their criteria for what constitutes a "good college." This insightful guide not only demystifies the admissions process but also empowers students to better understand their strengths and find the right fit for their educational aspirations.

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About the author

Jeffrey J. Selingo is a renowned expert in the field of higher education and serves as the editorial director of The Chronicle of Higher Education. With a prominent voice in discussions about educational access and admissions, he frequently shares his insights as a sought-after commentator on national platforms, including NPR, PBS, ABC, and CBS.

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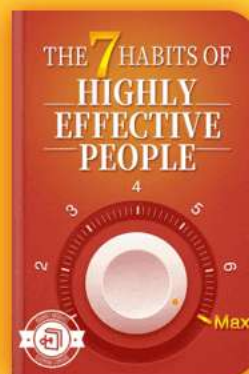
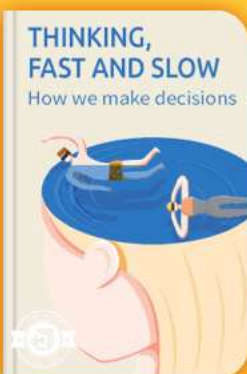


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Chapter 1 : Part One: Fall: Recruitment Season

Chapter 2 : Part Two: Winter: Reading Season

Chapter 3 : Part Three: Spring: Decision Season

Chapter 4 : Conclusion: Charting the Future

Chapter 5 : Appendix: Getting In: What Matters Most

Chapter 6 : Acknowledgments

Chapter 7 : Notes

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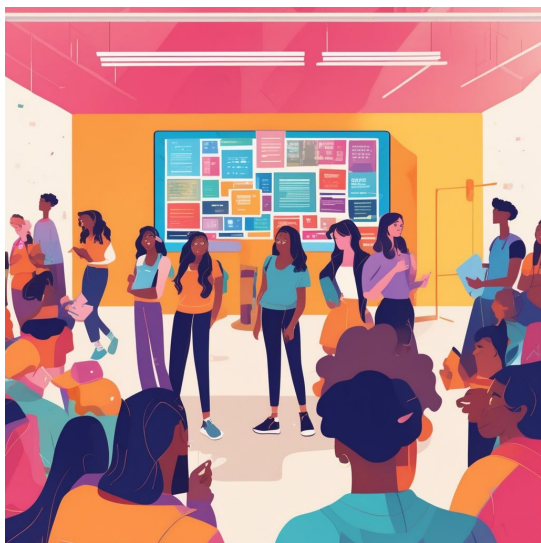


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Chapter 1 Summary : Part One: Fall: Recruitment Season



PART ONE FALL: Recruitment Season

Selling a College: The Endless Pursuit of Students

The journey of college recruitment is often initiated through colorful brochures and marketing materials flooding the mailboxes of American teenagers. This chapter chronicles the historical evolution of college marketing, with emphasis on the significant impact made by Bill Royall, a pioneer in direct mail strategies for higher education. His firm, Royall & Company, began working with colleges in the late 1980s,

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transforming how institutions marketed themselves to prospective students by leveraging demographics, technology, and targeted messaging. The goal was clear: bolster application numbers to enhance institutional prestige. Colleges traditionally depended on limited data and neglected robust outreach efforts. However, Royall introduced innovative strategies like A/B testing and personalized mailings, leading to more successful student engagement. The marketing techniques that emerged turned student recruitment into a competitive business worth around \$10 billion annually.

Historically, college admissions were less structured, but demand for higher education surged in the post-World War II era, leading to the establishment of a modern admissions infrastructure. Competition increased, with more colleges seeking to attract a limited pool of students. Official statistics regarding applications and acceptance rates became public, spurring a shift from recruitment to selection, heightening pressure on both institutions and students.

As the chapter continues, it highlights a change in attitudes toward marketing in college admissions, with institutions realizing the necessity to attract students rather than wait for them to apply. The College Board's introduction of the Student Search Service facilitated this change by allowing

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colleges to purchase lists of prospective students based on standardized test scores. Consequently, colleges aggressively marketed themselves, increasing the volume of mailings and outreach to potential applicants.

Recruitment Tactics and the Search Landscape

Colleges began to employ aggressive marketing tactics, akin to those used by retail businesses, leading to a barrage of communication directed at prospective students. Institutions sought specific demographics, often aiming for students from affluent backgrounds while trying to maintain a diverse applicant pool.

Despite the overwhelming marketing efforts, high school students displayed an indifference towards most incoming communications, often disregarding the dozens of brochures and emails they received. The authors argue that behind this bombardment lies a stark reality: many colleges wish to appear selective and prestigious, increasing their desirability among peers and potential applicants.

Amidst the chaos of college searches, students often struggle to find clarity. Some families, especially those with less experience navigating higher education, can feel lost among the sea of information. This disparity creates a divide

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between the "drivers" who actively seek and engage with college planning resources and the "passengers" who let circumstances guide them.

Defining Prestige: The Buyers and Sellers

The chapter transitions into the dynamics of college fairs, highlighting that not all colleges are created equal. Some institutions are highly sought after ("sellers"), owning prestigious brands that attract large applicant pools, while others ("buyers") work hard to fill seats, often through merit-based scholarship offers.

Understanding the distinction between buyers and sellers becomes crucial for students navigating college admissions. Many top schools do not need to entice students with discounts, while less prestigious institutions may rely heavily on financial aid to attract good candidates. As students begin to realize that prestige isn't always tied to best fit, those driven by reputation may overlook solid institutions that fit their academic and financial needs.

In today's competitive admissions landscape, navigating the complexities of financial aid, institutional priorities, and personal fit is essential. The chapter stresses the importance of broadening perspectives and considering a range of

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options beyond elite brands, as personal and financial compatibility may offer greater value than prestige alone. The narrative concludes with the understanding that while colleges try to innovate their approach to attract and recruit students, the fundamental dynamics of the admissions process continue to evolve, shaped by marketing, reputation, and institutional priorities.

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Example

Key Point: The importance of understanding the distinction between 'buyers' and 'sellers' in college admissions.

Example: Imagine you are a high school senior, sifting through college brochures and hearing about elite institutions from your friends. As you consider your options, it's essential to realize that while top-tier colleges may seem like the ultimate goal, many less prestigious schools offer great programs and financial aid that can better suit your academic needs.

Recognizing this distinction empowers you to avoid the trap of chasing prestige and instead focus on what fits your personal and financial situation best.

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Chapter 2 Summary : Part Two: Winter: Reading Season



PART TWO: WINTER: Reading Season

3. Understanding Merit

Look at All the Bs

Mark Butt, an admissions officer at Emory University, reviews high school transcripts, noting rigor and diversity in courses. An applicant aiming to major in physics has taken Advanced Placement (AP) courses but also has Bs, causing

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Mark to assess him as potentially undecided in his major due to interests in the arts.

Admissions Process Insight

Admissions officers use ratings from 1 to 5 across categories like curriculum, activities, and intellectual curiosity to evaluate applicants. The system appears precise but is ultimately subjective. As admissions cycles progress, they sort applications into accept, deny, or waitlist.

Holistic Admissions Overview

The holistic review process allows for a broader understanding of a student, but it also raises questions about fairness, especially as admissions teams grapple with strict deadlines, high volumes of applications, and the need for diverse student bodies. Many parents and students seek clarity and simplicity in admissions criteria, desiring a formula while grappling with subjective measures.

Changing Definitions of Merit

The definition of merit in admissions shifts based on

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evolving institutional needs, with a long history of preserving social orders. Recent efforts aim to enhance recruitment of low-income and diverse students in response to scrutiny regarding admissions bias.

Admissions Criteria and Context

Admittance often hinges more on an applicant's overall academic story rather than isolated metrics. Holistic admissions don't just assess grades and test scores but also contextualize them with the applicant's high school experience and personal narrative.

Navigating the Application Process

Students often submit multiple applications without a coherent narrative, compromising their chances. Effective application strategies require time, commitment, and attention to detailing their unique story.

Decision-Making in Admissions

Admissions readers face challenging decisions and will sometimes favor students with unique backgrounds or

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commitments, reflecting on how an applicant adds value to the university community. The pressures of competition mean that not every capable student will gain acceptance.

Changing Dynamics and Numbers

With the increasing applicant pool, the number of students denied admission rises, making it harder for capable candidates to secure spots. The admissions process continues to evolve, reflecting broader societal changes.

The Role of High Schools in Admissions

College admissions prioritizes high school context, with selective schools increasingly relying on known feeder schools and their graduates' profiles. A student's school's reputation can heavily influence their application success.

Emerging Trends in Youth Sports and Admissions

College athletics provide admissions hooks, with a substantial preference shown towards student-athletes in admissions processes. Yet, the reality of athletic scholarships differs significantly from popular perception.

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Comparative Advantage of Legacy Applicants

Legacy admissions benefit children of alumni and are contextually advantageous, with a noted tendency for universities to favor them in the admissions process.

Concluding Notes on the Admissions Landscape

The landscape of college admissions is complex, filled with shifting definitions of merit, subjective reviews, and an array of factors beyond the direct performance indicators. Understanding the broader context of an applicant's education can be as essential as the individual accomplishments on their application.

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Critical Thinking

Key Point: Changing Definitions of Merit

Critical Interpretation: One crucial point is the evolving definition of merit in college admissions, which reflects institutions' needs to maintain diversity. While Selingo emphasizes fairness and adaptability in the admissions processes, this perspective can be challenged. The subjective nature of what constitutes 'merit' creates complications for students from varied backgrounds. Critics argue that a singular formula for merit may be preferable, citing evidence from sources like 'The New York Times' and studies on educational equity, which suggest that clear criteria could better level the playing field. Therefore, while the holistic review process aims to provide a comprehensive evaluation, its subjective components may inadvertently perpetuate disparities.

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Chapter 3 Summary : Part Three:

Spring: Decision Season

Section	Summary
Shaping a Class: The Decision Process in Admissions	Davidson College's admissions office narrows down over 5,000 applications to about 715 admits, focusing on applicant qualifications and likelihood to enroll.
Criteria and Challenges in Admissions	Admissions incorporate demographics, academic rigor, and personal narratives; candidates lacking demonstrated interest or from common backgrounds face rejection.
Yield Rate and Class Composition	Yield rates are critical for shaping a diverse class, balancing gender, race, and academic backgrounds, sometimes prioritizing institutional needs over merit.
Financial Considerations in Admissions	Financial need impacts the acceptance of international and needy applicants in need-aware institutions, affecting admissions under budget constraints.
The Waitlist: A Tool for Stability	Waitlists help manage yield rates, as colleges place many applicants, often more than those accepted, to fill spots if students decline offers.
Need-Aware vs. Need-Blind Admissions	The chapter compares need-aware and need-blind institutions, emphasizing how financial need influences admissions in selective colleges with limited aid.
The Emotional Toll of Admission Decisions	Admission decisions cause emotional distress for students whose aspirations depend on acceptance, highlighting the conflict between dreams and reality.
Final Thoughts on College Selection	Choosing a college should prioritize personal fit and future opportunities over prestige, focusing on affordability and learning environment rather than rankings.

Summary of Chapter 3: Who Gets In and Why

Shaping a Class: The Decision Process in Admissions

In late February, Davidson College's admissions office strategizes to reduce a pool of over 5,000 applications down

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to approximately 715 admits. Admissions officers like Mike Mansuy analyze a large number of applications, discussing qualified students while considering their likelihood to enroll (LTE). They focus on differentiating factors among applicants as the final admissions decisions approach.

Criteria and Challenges in Admissions

Admissions decisions often incorporate various considerations, including school demographics, academic rigor, and personal narratives. Candidates who do not explicitly demonstrate interest in Davidson or who come from common applicant backgrounds often face rejection. Conversations surrounding certain applicants reveal the harsh realities of the admissions process, where the desirability of a candidate can hinge on factors beyond academic performance.

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Chapter 4 Summary : Conclusion:

Charting the Future

Conclusion

Charting the Future

College admissions offices are typically entrenched in tradition, employing standard practices such as campus tours and common application deadlines. Though the admissions landscape has experienced infrequent major changes, it has remained relatively stable compared to other industries. This stability is largely due to regulations that govern higher education, compelling colleges to operate similarly, akin to a cartel. The admissions process is dominated by prominent institutions setting the pace, while those with fewer resources tend to follow.

However, gradual transformations are on the horizon, influenced by Generation Z, government actions, and changes within colleges. Gen Z is increasingly using alternative channels, such as social media platforms, to

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discover colleges, often disregarding traditional marketing. This cohort is also likely to embrace a more nuanced view of college fit, realizing that their college experience is shaped more by personal effort than promotional materials.

Government deregulation has led to increasing competition among colleges, prompting them to offer incentives to attract applicants. Additionally, a growing number of institutions are dropping standardized testing requirements, allowing a broader range of students to navigate admissions.

As demographics shift and the number of high school graduates declines, we may witness a polarization in higher education. Wealthy colleges may increasingly secure the best applicants, while less resourced institutions struggle to maintain enrollment. This divide raises concerns about retaining underrepresented student populations and aiding their academic success.

Proposed Changes to Admissions

To navigate future challenges in admissions, several suggestions are made:

1.

Empower Students and Parents

: Encourage students to focus on personal interests rather

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than chasing prestige. Allow for flexibility in their college search process.

2.

Government Intervention

: The federal government could mandate that colleges adjust their recruitment strategies, similar to how athletes are recruited.

3.

Redesign Applications

: Admissions processes should prioritize meaningful assessments and reduce dependency on less reliable indicators.

4.

Expand Capacity

: Colleges should consider increasing enrollment numbers while ensuring a diverse socioeconomic representation.

5.

Transparency in Costs

: Providing clearer information about financial aid and actual costs can help students make informed decisions early in their search.

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These recommendations seek to empower individuals in the admissions process and foster a more equitable college selection landscape, all while acknowledging that the fundamental motivations of higher education institutions are unlikely to change. The overarching concern remains the potential impact of these changes on societal equity and access to education.

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Chapter 5 Summary : Appendix: Getting In: What Matters Most

Appendix: Getting In: What Matters Most

Before the research for this book, the author explored various sources to understand the college admissions landscape, discovering a wealth of information available to prospective students and their parents. The current college search process can be overwhelming due to the abundance of resources, but the author emphasizes focusing on key areas of importance.

1. Focus on High School Performance over Test Scores

- Emphasize participation and performance in high school activities rather than solely on standardized tests like the SAT or ACT.
- Freshman year is crucial for laying the foundation for future academic choices; thus, students should take prerequisite courses and explore interests.
- Admissions officers prioritize strength of schedule and

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consistent grades; a GPA trend matters more than taking numerous AP courses.

- Seek diverse recommendations that reflect a broad range of interests and allow for early requests to avoid being overlooked.

2. Create a College List Based on Personal Needs

- Develop an initial college list focusing on personal requirements rather than rankings.
- Discuss options with those who've attended various colleges and engage in campus visits for a better sense of fit.
- Balance the college list among likely, target, and reach schools, and ensure financial considerations are part of the planning process.

3. Individualize Each Application

- Approach each college application as a separate endeavor, providing authentic and relevant information tailored to each institution.
- Avoid generic submissions; share what is most meaningful and ensure that recommenders align with the application focus.

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- Consider your application as a narrative that portrays your journey, interests, and goals clearly to the admissions officers.

4. Seek the Best Fit over Prestige

- Regularly revisit what matters most in college to ensure decisions are aligned with personal values and aspirations, not external pressures.
- Prioritize acquiring relevant skills and experiences over achievements and rankings; the college experience should foster employability.
- Evaluate financial implications early, as the cost of education influences post-college opportunities and career flexibility.
- Understand that potential earnings can vary greatly within majors, challenging preconceived notions about job prospects tied to specific fields.

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Chapter 6 Summary : Acknowledgments

Acknowledgments

This chapter expresses deep gratitude to all those who contributed to the creation of the book, particularly those involved in the admissions processes at Davidson College, Emory University, and the University of Washington. Special thanks are given to individuals who facilitated access to their offices, provided insights, and shared their experiences during the admissions cycle. The author acknowledges the importance of the collaboration from various students, parents, counselors, and organizations who aided in understanding the admissions landscape. A heartfelt appreciation is also extended to friends, family, and colleagues for their support throughout the writing process.

Notes

The book is based on nearly two years of reporting and interviews with various stakeholders in the college admissions process. Information is drawn from sources like IPEDS and U.S. News rankings, with care taken to protect

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the identities of students. Data on admissions and various studies provide context, revealing the intricate and often challenging nature of the admissions landscape.

Introduction: Steering the College's Agenda

The introduction highlights critical statistics regarding college admissions and demographic trends, setting the stage for the discussions in subsequent chapters. It sheds light on the complexities of the admissions process, including disparities in representation among different racial and socioeconomic groups, and describes the recruitment landscape as a competitive environment for colleges.

Chapter Summaries (Chapters 1-10)

-

Chapter 1: Selling a College:

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great concept !!!highly recommended!

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busy schedules. The summaries are spot
on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh
I've learned. Highly recommend!

Alex Walk

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Chapter 7 Summary : Notes

Summary of Chapter 7: Finding Diamonds: Regular Decision

This chapter discusses the regular decision process in college admissions, highlighting various factors that influence applicants' chances and outcomes.

Key Points:

1.

Historical Context

: The narrative begins by referencing a significant donation to Emory University, illustrating the long-standing connection between financial contributions and institutional prestige.

2.

Academic Performance Indicators

: It emphasizes the relationship between standardized test scores and GPAs, noting that many students with low GPAs may excel in rigorous coursework, thus complicating straightforward assessments of academic potential.

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3.

Letters of Recommendation

: The quality and content of letters of recommendation are examined, pointing out how their effectiveness can differ based on high school backgrounds.

4.

Gender Dynamics

: The gender distribution in college admissions is analyzed, highlighting that acceptance rates often vary between male and female applicants.

5.

Admissions Strategies

: The use of waitlists as a tactic to manage application outcomes is discussed, especially among top-ranked institutions, which often aim to balance gender and other demographic factors in their final class composition.

6.

Financial Implications

: The chapter touches on financial aid dynamics and the transparency (or lack thereof) in financial aid award letters, which can impact student choices.

Overall, this chapter provides an in-depth look at the nuances of regular decision admissions, considering how historical, academic, and financial factors interplay in shaping student diversity and success in higher education.

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Best Quotes from Who Gets In and Why by Jeffrey J. Selingo with Page Numbers

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Chapter 1 | Quotes From Pages 47-156

1. We want the best and only the best, we are never satisfied.
2. Once admissions statistics became public, they came to signify a college's quality.
3. That type of marketing altered the way parents and their children thought about going to college.
4. Choosing the right college ... is difficult because we lack the tools to make bottom-line comparisons between options.
5. There is life beyond the elite, prestigious, brand-name schools.

Chapter 2 | Quotes From Pages 157-362

1. What would he do at Emory?" Mark asks a colleague.
2. It's a classic 3.95," Giselle tells Jetaun, "where you go

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undercover by taking easier classes.

3.He's a flat, one-dimensional student.

4.That means that for much of their history colleges focused on preserving the admission of white men.

5.The whole process is about finding potential.

6.What colleges can't do is know anything about the individual student.

7.The more students who go to college from that high school, the more willing they are to take a chance in accepting students ranked lower in the class.

Chapter 3 | Quotes From Pages 363-454

1.Students see admissions as a report card on their life until now," Gruber told me, "but there are so many attributes that we're looking at in the end to build a community.

2.She is totally unflappable," the counselor wrote about the student.

3.It's about what we're looking for. That's what's going to determine who stays as an admit and who goes down a step

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or two.

4. There's not one decision, but many.

5. It leaves something to be desired," someone says.

6. Do we have enough African American students or Latino students? Enough students who can pay the bulk of the tuition bill?

7. Admissions officers loathe the shaping process.

8. College is sold in the marketing materials and on the tours as a celebratory rite of passage.

9. Sometimes I wish I was around people from my hometown or high school.

10. The anxiety about getting into a brand-name school starts with a single, fundamental principle believed by students and parents in top high schools: it matters where you go to college.

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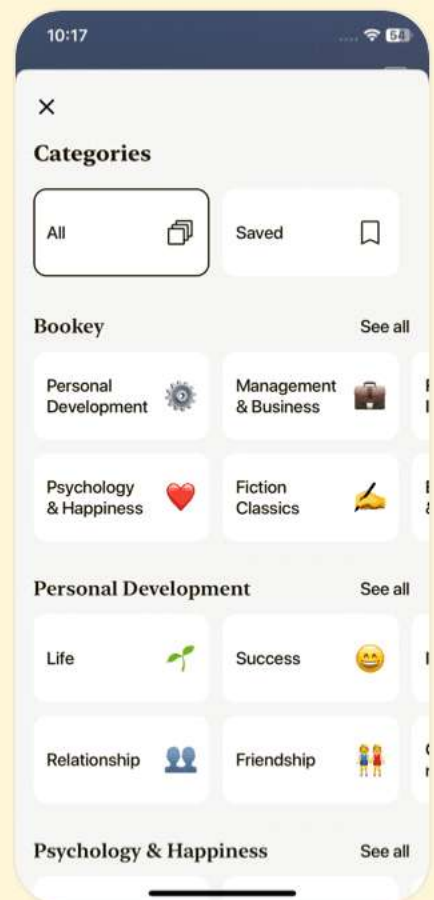
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Chapter 4 | Quotes From Pages 455-481

1.Colleges and universities operate like a cartel.

Nowhere is that more evident than when trying to gain access to their front door: the admissions office.

2.If Gen Z is able to discover colleges through their own channels, they'll end up ignoring the gobs of traditional propaganda from colleges even more than they do already.

3.When they tied it all together... I didn't need to see the testing to know that this kid was going to come here and be a rock star.

4.The real purpose of admissions at a top college is that of gatekeeper—that is, to turn away the vast majority of applicants.

5.Students essentially let colleges tell them what should matter in high school, and even in life. Turn the tables.

6.Admissions deans rarely take the long view, either. They're constantly worried about the year ahead... making their next class, meeting their financial aid budget.

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7. There is no admissions officer—no matter how experienced, no matter how much information they possess... who can predict who will succeed at a particular school and how far they will eventually travel in life.

Chapter 5 | Quotes From Pages 482-491

1. Colleges know that, so most pay little, if any, attention to what you do in ninth grade.
2. Take the hardest courses available, but also what interests you.
3. Gather information from those around you.
4. Resist cutting and pasting from a Google doc to fill in the blanks on the Common App or to complete a supplemental question about why you want to go to X school.
5. Think about what fits you rather than how good the sticker looks on the back of your family's car window.

Chapter 6 | Quotes From Pages 492-558

1. My parents, Jim and Carmella, sacrificed so much for their children to have a great life and education.

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- 2.The college search is a stressful process for most students, and it comes during some of the most anxious years of one's life.
- 3.My agent, Gail Ross, once again prodded me to push forward on the idea for this book and helped shape the proposal, and her tough love got me to the finish line.
- 4.I'm especially grateful to the three students featured in the book for sharing their stories: Grace, Nicole, and Chris.
- 5.I wish I could have included all of their stories so the rest of the world could see the devotion with which they approach their work.
- 6.I'm lucky to have two of the best in-laws in the world, Gene and Sandy Salko, who will drop anything at a moment's notice to help out.
- 7.I know you've helped make me a better person every day, and this book is for you.

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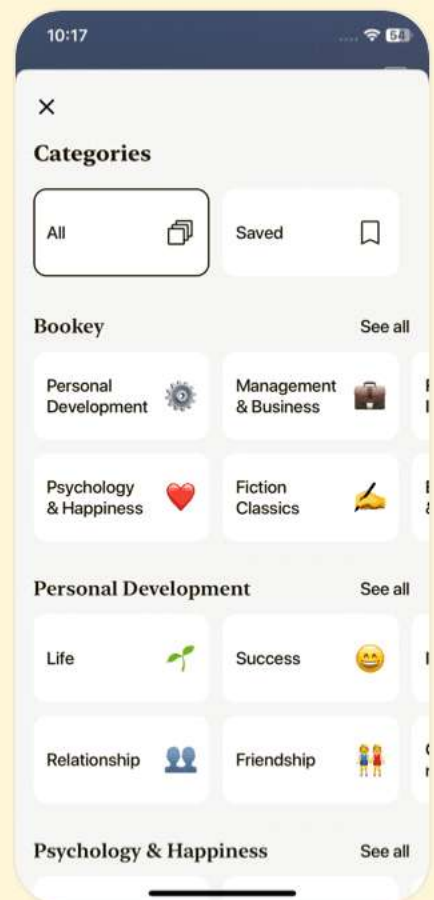
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Chapter 7 | Quotes From Pages 561-584

1. More selective institutions in the United States account for about one-third of all applications.
2. Applicants pay attention to rankings.
3. The average acceptance rate for Early Decision is more than 10 percentage points higher than for Regular Decision.
4. The gender divide on college campuses cuts across racial and ethnic lines.
5. The rankings can be somewhat misleading, with little variation between the schools at the top.

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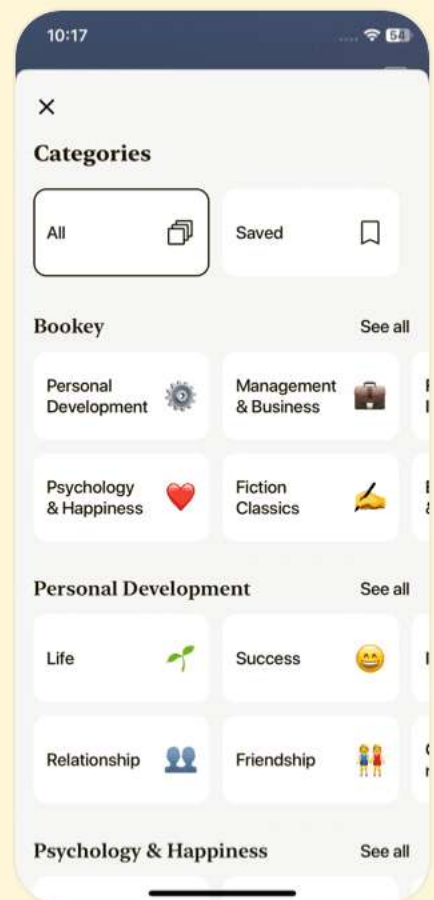
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Who Gets In and Why Questions

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Chapter 1 | Part One: Fall: Recruitment Season| Q&A

1.Question

What role does marketing play in college admissions according to the text?

Answer:Marketing is crucial in college admissions as it helps institutions attract potential students and build their brand. Bill Royall's strategies revolutionized how colleges engage with prospective students, flooding mailboxes with brochures and personalized letters to create a sense of interest and urgency.

2.Question

How has the perception of college prestige changed among students and parents?

Answer:Prestige is now largely tied to selectivity and brand name recognition. Students and parents often prioritize 'elite' institutions, believing that acceptance into a prestigious

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college is synonymous with future success, leading to a narrowed search that influences their college choices.

3.Question

What are the implications of the college rankings on school selection and applicant strategies?

Answer:College rankings have created a culture where students focus on a small number of selective schools, often ignoring other potentially valuable options. This influences how colleges market themselves, pushing them to aim for higher rankings, which impacts admissions practices and financial aid distribution.

4.Question

Why might students overlook less prestigious colleges during their search?

Answer:Students often focus on brand names and the perception of quality associated with elite institutions, disregarding smaller or less recognized colleges that may offer high-quality education and better financial aid opportunities.

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5.Question

What challenges do students face when navigating the college admissions process today?

Answer:Students encounter overwhelming amounts of information, marketing tactics targeting them from numerous colleges, and pressure from peers and parents to gain acceptance into prestigious schools. This can create anxiety and lead to flawed decision-making in their college search.

6.Question

How has the demographic shift affected college admissions practices?

Answer:Colleges are facing declining numbers of high school graduates, prompting them to adopt aggressive marketing strategies to recruit students. This includes purchasing large mail lists and ramping up outreach to entice potential applicants.

7.Question

In what ways has the college search become a commercialized process?

Answer:The process has shifted towards a business model

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where admissions are treated like sales, focusing on attracting applicants through marketing strategies, portrait-driven viewbooks, and the strategic use of financial aid to entice students.

8.Question

What can students do to better prepare for their college search?

Answer:Students should start their search early, explore a wide range of colleges, and consider factors beyond prestige, such as academic offerings, campus culture, and financial aid options, to find a good fit.

9.Question

How do familial and social influences shape students' college choices?

Answer:Parents, peers, and social environments heavily influence students' perceptions of college value, often leading them to prioritize schools based on reputation rather than personal fit or practical considerations.

Chapter 2 | Part Two: Winter: Reading Season| Q&A

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1.Question

What did Mark Butt find most impressive about the applicant from the private high school on the West Coast?

Answer:Mark was particularly impressed by the applicant's balanced curriculum that included Advanced Placement courses in both rigorous subjects like calculus and physics, as well as courses in painting and ceramics, indicating a well-rounded individual who values both science and the arts.

2.Question

How does the admissions officer determine whether to accept or deny an application?

Answer:Admissions officers evaluate each application by comparing grades, test scores, extracurricular activities, recommendations, and the applicant's overall fit with the school's needs at that moment. Even outstanding applicants can be denied based on the perceived depth of their experiences and the unique qualities they bring to the incoming class.

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3.Question

What is the significance of holistic admissions according to the text?

Answer: Holistic admissions prioritize the entire student experience rather than just grades and test scores. They allow colleges to take into account unique backgrounds, interests, and personal stories, but the process can lead to subjective decision-making and confusion among applicants and parents regarding fairness and transparency.

4.Question

Why is it challenging for high school students to navigate the college admissions process?

Answer: High school students often rush through applications without fully crafting and expressing their personal stories, mistakenly thinking that generic answers will suffice across different applications. The complexities of how different colleges evaluate merit and the subjective nature of holistic admissions make it difficult for them to understand how to present themselves effectively.

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5.Question

What has changed about the definition of merit in college admissions over time?

Answer:The definition of merit has evolved from a focus primarily on academic achievement, to a more nuanced understanding that includes diverse experiences, interests, and contributions to the community, reflecting changes in societal expectations and the growing importance of diversity in the student body.

6.Question

What insights do admissions officers share regarding the story behind an applicant's achievements?

Answer:Admissions officers look for the narrative that ties an applicant's achievements together, valuing consistent efforts over time and the ability to manage challenges or interests outside of academics. A compelling personal story can sometimes elevate an application that might otherwise fall flat due to standard metrics.

7.Question

Why do college admissions offices emphasize

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individualized recommendations?

Answer: Individualized recommendations provide a personal context that helps admissions officers understand an applicant's character and potential, beyond what can be gleaned from grades and standardized tests. Strong, personalized letters can highlight a student's unique contributions and insights that are not evident in the application.

8.Question

What role do extracurricular activities play in the admissions process?

Answer: Extracurricular activities are critical in illustrating a student's interests outside academics and can show leadership, dedication, and community involvement.

However, admissions officers prefer depth and meaningful engagement over a mere list of activities.

9.Question

How can students demonstrate their interests effectively in their college applications?

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Answer: Students can demonstrate their interests effectively by providing detailed accounts of their activities, the impact of their involvement, and insights into their passions in their essays and through their recommendations, rather than relying only on achievements or accolades.

10. Question

What does Mark Butt's experience reveal about the subjective nature of college admissions?

Answer: Mark Butt's experience illustrates that despite efforts to maintain objective criteria in admissions, personal biases, stories, and perceptions greatly influence decision-making, leading to inconsistencies and subjective judgments within the admissions process.

Chapter 3 | Part Three: Spring: Decision Season| Q&A

1. Question

What factors influence admissions decisions at colleges like Davidson and Emory University?

Answer: Colleges like Davidson and Emory consider a variety of factors when making admissions

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decisions, including academic qualifications, extracurricular involvement, geographical diversity, and the likelihood to enroll (LTE). Admissions officers look for students who will enrich the campus community while still balancing institutional priorities such as yield rates and financial considerations. The process is not strictly merit-based; factors such as race, gender, financial need, and applicant backgrounds come into play, particularly during the final stages of selection.

2.Question

What is the shaping process in college admissions?

Answer: The shaping process is the final stage of college admissions where admissions committees make decisions about which applicants to accept based on the overall composition they wish to create for the incoming class. This includes considerations of diversity, gender balance, and specific academic programs. Essentially, it is about carefully crafting a class that meets the college's goals while also

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ensuring that students accepted have a high likelihood of attending.

3.Question

How do colleges handle wait-listed students?

Answer:Colleges use wait lists as a tool to manage admissions uncertainty. When they anticipate not all acceptances will convert to enrollments, they offer spots on the wait list. While the odds of being admitted off the wait list can be low, being wait-listed is often seen as a more favorable outcome than a rejection. Colleges may select from the wait list based on needs such as adding diversity or filling specific program spots, and they often do so ahead of the May 1 decision deadline.

4.Question

How does financial need impact admissions decisions at colleges?

Answer:Financial need plays a crucial role in admissions decisions, particularly for colleges that are need-aware.

These institutions consider an applicant's ability to pay at

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some stage during the selection process, which can lead to rejections of qualified students if their financial needs exceed what the college can provide. In contrast, need-blind colleges claim to make admissions decisions without regard to financial circumstances but may still be influenced by the zip codes and background of applicants.

5.Question

What are the implications of the 'cultivating potential' mentality among parents regarding college choices?

Answer:Parents often cling to the belief that attending a prestigious college is essential for their children's success.

This can lead to significant financial sacrifices and a focus on brand-name schools over quality education or fit. Many families prioritize an elite institution based on perceived value rather than critical evaluations of cost, financial aid, and the fit between the student and the institution. This mentality can overshadow practical decisions that would benefit both student and family in the long run.

6.Question

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Why is campus visit critical in the college admissions process?

Answer: Campus visits are critical because they greatly influence a student's final decision about where to enroll. Research shows that the experience of being on campus—interacting with current students, seeing facilities, and feeling the atmosphere—can be decisive. Colleges use open houses and yield events to try and create a sense of belonging and appeal to prospective students, as personal experiences often hold more weight than brochures or online searches.

7.Question

What does the 'financial aid leveraging' concept involve?

Answer: Financial aid leveraging involves strategically using financial aid funds to attract desirable students. Colleges analyze various data points to determine how much aid to offer an applicant based on their potential enrollment likelihood, balancing financial need with institutional priorities. This practice allows colleges to maximize tuition

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revenue while enticing students, particularly those who may not qualify for need-based aid but whose acceptance would enhance the school's profile or fill gaps in enrollment.

8.Question

How do students typically navigate their college decisions after receiving acceptance letters?

Answer:After receiving acceptance letters, students often weigh the offers against not only academic programs but also the financial aid packages. Many students feel pressure from their families to choose prestigious schools despite costs, leading to discussions about affordability and potential debt. Typically, students balance their dreams with practical considerations, adjusting their expectations and ultimately selecting schools that may not have been their first choice but better meet their financial and personal needs.

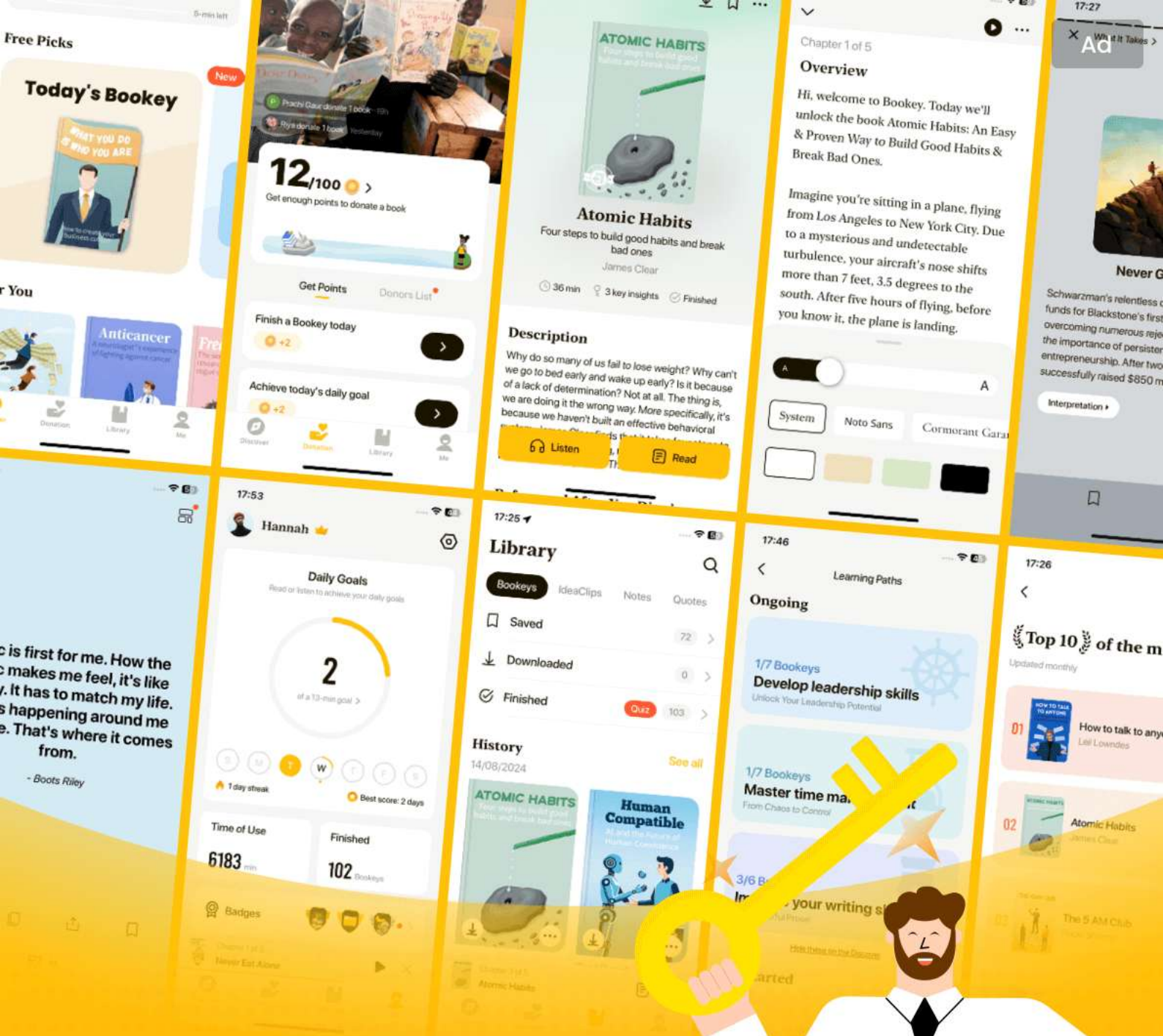
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Chapter 4 | Conclusion: Charting the Future| Q&A

1.Question

What are key changes currently observed in the college admissions process?

Answer:The college admissions process is witnessing several significant changes:

1. ****Decline of Standardized Tests****: More than 1,000 colleges have made tests like the SAT and ACT optional, recognizing that other aspects of applications can indicate potential success.
2. ****Rise of Alternative Discoverability Channels****: Generation Z is relying on platforms like YouTube and Reddit for college insights instead of traditional college marketing tactics.
3. ****End of NACAC Ethics Code****: The elimination of guidelines that prohibited colleges from aggressively recruiting applicants post-acceptance decision is likely to increase competitive offers like scholarships and housing perks for early decision

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applicants.

4. ****Demographic Shifts****: A decline in high school graduates and the anticipated growth of Latino and first-generation college-bound students are expected to reshape the admissions landscape.

Chapter 5 | Appendix: Getting In: What Matters Most| Q&A

1.Question

What should students focus on during high school to better prepare for college admissions?

Answer: Students should prioritize their academic and extracurricular commitments during high school. Specifically, they should take challenging courses that align with their interests, maintain consistent grades throughout high school, and avoid skipping upper-level classes even if they find them challenging. Admissions officers highly value the strength of the schedule and overall performance, rather than overly focusing on standardized test scores.

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2.Question

How can students effectively narrow down their college list?

Answer:Students should create an initial college list based on their personal needs and preferences rather than external rankings. Gathering firsthand information from former students, visiting campuses, and understanding the differences between types of institutions can help students balance their list with a mix of safety, target, and reach schools. Additionally, considering financial implications is crucial—making sure they choose schools that are financially feasible.

3.Question

Why is it important to tailor college applications to individual schools?

Answer:Tailoring applications allows students to convey their unique stories and interests to admissions officers.

Rather than using generic responses, students should clearly articulate why each college is a fit for them and highlight

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relevant experiences and achievements. This approach helps admissions officers understand the applicant's personality and what makes them a strong candidate.

4.Question

What is the significance of focusing on personal fit rather than prestige in the college selection process?

Answer:Choosing a college should center around personal fit and what aligns with the student's values and career aspirations. This perspective encourages students to consider how their college experience, including relationships and opportunities, will influence their future—emphasizing skills over the allure of a prestigious name. Ultimately, the experiences and connections made during undergraduate years are far more important than the image associated with a college.

5.Question

How can students approach the financial aspect of college without losing focus on their educational goals?

Answer:Students should integrate financial considerations

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into their college search from the beginning. Understanding the long-term impacts of student debt on career choices is critical. They should identify colleges that offer a balance of quality education and financial support, seeking 'buyers' that provide merit aid, rather than simply following peers' paths or decisions based on temporary financial gains.

Chapter 6 | Acknowledgments| Q&A

1.Question

What elements contribute to the admissions process in colleges and universities according to the author?

Answer: The admissions process involves several elements including academic performance (such as GPA and standardized test scores), rigorous high school curriculum, extracurricular activities, personal essays, recommendations, and demonstrated interest in the school. It also considers the college's own institutional priorities, which can include diversity goals, financial considerations, and the applicant's background.

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2.Question

How does the author describe the relationship between a student's high school performance and college admission outcomes?

Answer:The author highlights that high school performance, particularly grades and the rigor of coursework, plays a critical role in college admissions. Many students who take advanced courses like AP or IB tend to have better outcomes in college admissions, as it reflects their readiness for the academic challenges of higher education.

3.Question

Can you explain the effect of socio-economic status on the college admissions process?

Answer:Socio-economic status significantly affects college admissions, as wealthier applicants often have access to better preparation resources, extracurricular opportunities, and guidance. This can lead to higher acceptance rates for students from affluent backgrounds compared to their lower-income counterparts, who may face barriers that affect their admissions prospects.

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4.Question

What impact did institutional priorities have on the admissions decision process?

Answer:Institutional priorities, such as the desire to enhance diversity within the student body, can shape admissions decisions. Colleges may prioritize applicants from underrepresented backgrounds or those who demonstrate a commitment to diversity, impacting the makeup of accepted students and reflecting broader societal goals.

5.Question

Why is the concept of 'demonstrated interest' important in the admissions process?

Answer:Demonstrated interest indicates a student's genuine enthusiasm and commitment to a school, which can influence admissions decisions. Colleges often track interactions such as campus visits, attendance at information sessions, and communication with admissions officers, utilizing this data to assess potential yield—the likelihood that a student will accept an offer of admission.

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6.Question

How do the admissions processes at different types of colleges (like Ivy League vs. public universities) differ according to the author?

Answer: The author suggests that Ivy League and highly selective colleges may rely more heavily on subjective measures, such as personal essays and holistic reviews, compared to public universities which may focus more on quantitative metrics such as standardized test scores and GPAs. Selective colleges often aim for specific characteristics in their incoming classes to uphold prestige, while public universities may prioritize access for in-state applicants.

7.Question

What is the significance of knowing a high school's reputation in the college admissions process?

Answer: The reputation of a student's high school can significantly impact their college admissions outcomes, as admissions officers may have biases toward certain schools. They often utilize familiar metrics and histories of schools to

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gauge an applicant's potential, which means that students from well-regarded high schools may benefit from higher perceived merit in their applications.

8.Question

How does the author connect personal narratives of students with broader trends in college admissions?

Answer: The author uses personal stories from students to illustrate the emotional and subjective nature of the college admissions process. These narratives highlight the pressures faced by applicants, the diversity of experiences, and how individual stories weave into the larger systemic trends affecting admissions decisions across institutions.

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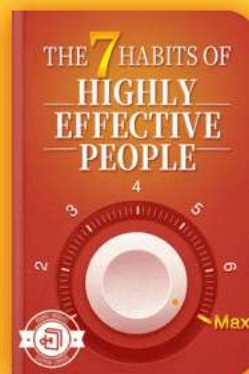
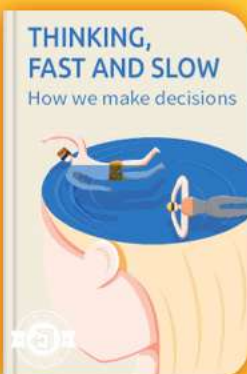


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Chapter 7 | Notes| Q&A

1.Question

What factors do high school students consider most important when choosing a college?

Answer:Students often prioritize selectivity and reputation over cost. This emphasis leads families to focus on prestigious institutions, sometimes at the expense of considering the overall financial implications.

2.Question

How does the concept of 'merit' factor into college admissions?

Answer:Merit is often defined by GPA and standardized test scores, but it can also reflect other social dynamics, such as race and socioeconomic background, which complicates the idea of meritocracy in college admissions.

3.Question

What role do letters of recommendation play in the admissions process?

Answer:Letters of recommendation are vital as they provide

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insights into a student beyond grades and scores, showing character, leadership potential, and how the student is perceived by teachers.

4.Question

How has college recruiting changed over the years?

Answer:Historically, fewer students applied to several colleges. Nowadays, it's common for students to apply to seven or more institutions, leading to what is called application inflation.

5.Question

What does the term 'demonstrated interest' mean in college admissions?

Answer:Demonstrated interest refers to the ways students show they are engaged and interested in a college, which can influence admission decisions. This might include campus visits, attending college fairs, or communicating with admissions officers.

6.Question

What challenges do low-income students face in the college admissions process?

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Answer:Low-income students often encounter barriers such as lack of access to resources for exam preparation, college counseling, and the financial capability to visit campuses, which can hinder their chances in the admissions process.

7.Question

What impact does the gender divide have on college admissions?

Answer:The gender divide in admissions reflects broader societal issues, with certain biases favoring one gender over another, complicating the process of achieving a fair and equal admission landscape.

8.Question

How does athletic recruitment influence college admissions?

Answer:Athletic prowess can significantly impact admissions, especially in highly selective schools where recruited athletes may receive favorable treatment compared to other applicants.

9.Question

What are some common misconceptions about college

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admissions?

Answer: Many believe that high test scores or prestigious extracurricular activities alone guarantee admission, but factors like personal essays, letters of recommendation, and demonstrated interest also weigh heavily.

10.Question

How can families better navigate the complexities of financial aid?

Answer: Families should seek transparent financial aid award letters and understand the full cost of attendance, including scholarships and work-study options, to make informed decisions about colleges.

11.Question

What are the implications of legacy admissions?

Answer: Legacy admissions can give an unfair advantage to applicants from privileged backgrounds, perpetuating inequality in higher education and limiting diversity among student populations.

12.Question

What strategies can students employ to enhance their

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college applications?

Answer: Students can focus on maintaining a rigorous course load, engaging in meaningful extracurricular activities, building strong relationships with teachers for compelling recommendations, and clearly articulating their passions in personal statements.

13.Question

Why is it important to consider school culture when choosing a college?

Answer: School culture can greatly impact a student's experience, influencing factors like community, support systems, and opportunities for personal growth, making it essential for students to find a school that matches their values and needs.

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Chapter 1 | Part One: Fall: Recruitment Season| Quiz and Test

- 1.Colleges in the post-World War II era experienced a surge in demand, leading to a more structured admissions infrastructure.
- 2.Bill Royall introduced traditional marketing methods that had been used by colleges prior to the 1980s, which limited their outreach efforts.
- 3.All colleges use similar tactics to attract students regardless of their prestige or financial situation.

Chapter 2 | Part Two: Winter: Reading Season| Quiz and Test

- 1.Admissions officers at Emory University only consider the grades of applicants and ignore the rigor and diversity of their courses.
- 2.The holistic review process in admissions aims to provide a broader understanding of a student's profile.

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3. Legacy applicants have no advantage in the admissions process compared to non-legacy applicants.

Chapter 3 | Part Three: Spring: Decision Season| Quiz and Test

1. Davidson College's admissions office reduces applications from over 5,000 to approximately 715 admits by focusing mainly on academic performance.
2. Colleges use waitlists as a strategy to manage yield rates and ensure they can fill seats if too many students decline offers.
3. Need-blind admissions mean financial need does not influence an applicant's chances of acceptance at colleges.

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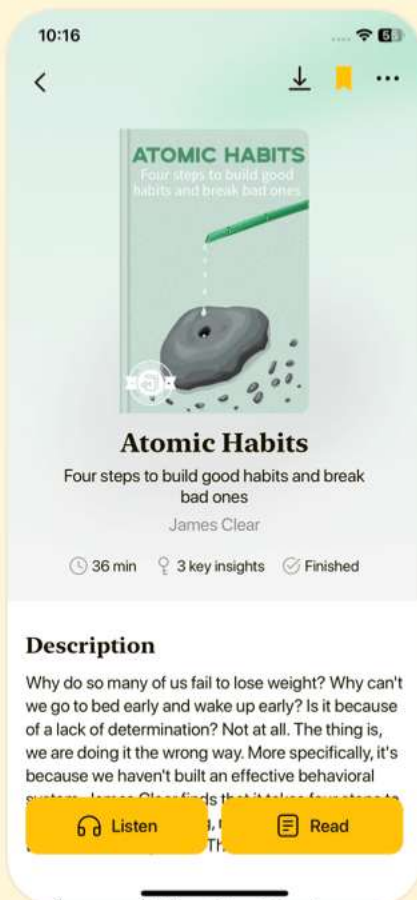


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Chapter 4 | Conclusion: Charting the Future| Quiz and Test

- 1.College admissions practices are influenced by government regulations, leading to a stable process that does not change often.
- 2.Generation Z prefers traditional marketing methods over social media when discovering colleges.
- 3.The suggested changes to admissions include empowering students to focus on prestige over personal interests.

Chapter 5 | Appendix: Getting In: What Matters Most| Quiz and Test

- 1.High school performance is prioritized over standardized test scores in college admissions.
- 2.Creating a college list should be based solely on the prestige of the institutions rather than personal needs.
- 3.Each college application should be individualized and tailored to reflect the applicant's personal journey and interests.

Chapter 6 | Acknowledgments| Quiz and Test

- 1.The author expresses gratitude mainly to

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individuals involved in the admissions processes at three universities: Davidson College, Emory University, and the University of Washington.

2. The book's primary focus is on the financial responsibilities of students and the budgeting process for college attendance.
3. The author acknowledges the importance of collaboration from various stakeholders like parents and counselors in understanding the admissions landscape.

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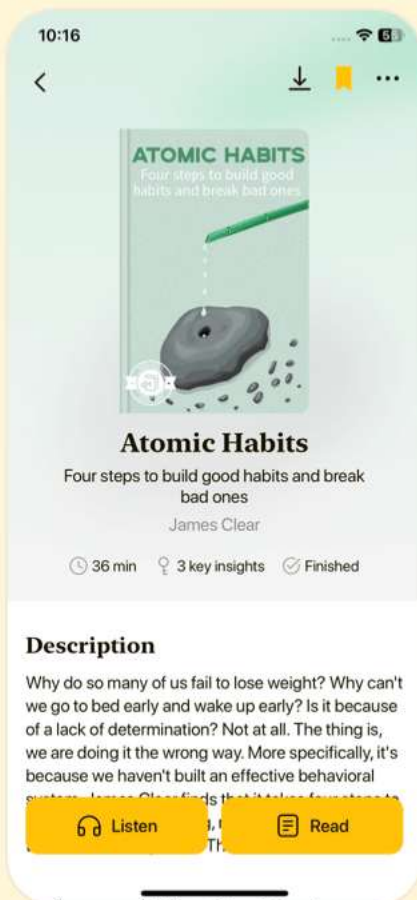


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Chapter 7 | Notes| Quiz and Test

- 1.The chapter discusses how financial contributions are connected to institutional prestige in college admissions.
- 2.Letters of recommendation are equally effective regardless of the high school background of the applicant.
- 3.Waitlists are primarily used by top-ranked institutions to ensure balance in the demographic composition of their admitted students.

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